

The Mysteries of Harris Burdick

Searchable transcript

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Source: `The\_mysteries\_of\_Harris\_Burdick\_Van\_z\_library\_sk,\_1lib\_sk,.pdf` (44 PDF pages; story on PDF pages 9-36)

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INTRODUCTION

I first saw the drawings in this book a year ago, in the home of a man named Peter Wenders. Though Mr. Wenders is retired now, he once worked for a children's book publisher, choosing the stories and pictures that would be turned into books.

Thirty years ago a man called at Peter Wenders's office, introducing himself as Harris Burdick. Mr. Burdick explained that he had written fourteen stories and had drawn many pictures for each one. He'd brought with him just one drawing from each story, to see if Wenders liked his work.

Peter Wenders was fascinated by the drawings. He told Burdick he would like to read the stories that went with them as soon as possible. The artist agreed to bring the stories the next morning. He left the fourteen drawings with Wenders.

But he did not return the next day. Or the day after that. Harris Burdick was never heard from again. Over the years, Wenders tried to find out who Burdick was and what had happened to him, but he discovered nothing. To this day Harris Burdick remains a complete mystery.

His disappearance is not the only mystery left behind. What were the stories that went with these drawings? There are some clues. Burdick had written a title and caption for each picture. When I told Peter Wenders how difficult it was to look at the drawings and their captions without imagining a story, he smiled and left the room. He returned with a dust-covered cardboard box. Inside were dozens of stories, all inspired by the Burdick drawings. They'd been written years ago by Wenders's children and their friends.

I spent the rest of my visit reading these stories. They were remarkable, some bizarre, some funny, some downright scary. In the hope that other children will be inspired by them, the Burdick drawings are reproduced here for the first time.

Chris Van Allsburg

Providence, Rhode Island

A tiny voice asked, "Is he the one?"

UNDER THE RUG

Two weeks passed and it happened again.

A STRANGE DAY IN JULY

He threw with all his might, but the third stone came skipping back.

MISSING IN VENICE

Even with her mighty engines in reverse, the ocean liner was pulled further and further into the canal.

ANOTHER PLAGE, ANOJHER TIME

If there was an answer, he'd find it there.

So its true he thought, its really true.

UNINVITED GUESTS

His heart was pounding. He was sure he had seen the doorknob turn.

MR. LINDEN'S LIBRARY

He had warned her about the book. Now it was too late.

THE SEVEN CHAIRS

The fifth one ended up in France.

THE THIRD-FLOOR BEDROOM

It all began when someone left the window open.

JUST DESERT

She lowered the knife and it grew even brighter.

He swung his lantern three times and slowly the schooner appeared.

OSCAR AND ALPHONSE

She knew it was time to send them back. The caterpillars softly wiggled in her hand, spelling out "goodbye."

THE HOUSE ON MAPLES TEREET

It was a perfect lift-off.

- The book opens with the Van Allsburg introduction: the retired publisher Peter Wenders, the vanished Harris Burdick, the fourteen orphaned drawings, and the box of children's stories.
- Each mystery pairs a full-page drawing with only a title and one-line caption: the rug's lump, the skipping third stone, the liner pulled into the canal, the doorknob that seems to turn.
- Standout spreads include the third-floor bedroom window, the glowing knife, the lantern-summoned schooner, the caterpillars spelling "goodbye," and the Maple Street lift-off.
- The closing matter collects praise for Van Allsburg's earlier books (The Garden of Abdul Gasazi, Jumanji, Ben's Dream, The Wreck of the Zephyr) rather than resolving any mystery.

Page map: introduction on PDF page 9; fourteen title-and-caption pairs on PDF pages 10, 12, 14, 16, 18, 20, 22, 24, 26, 28, 30, 32, 34, 36.

Removed from the story flow (titles preserved exactly as embedded, including scan substitutions):

- "" -- the "ARCHIE SMITH, BOY WONDER" caption is unreadable in the layer; not reconstructed.
- "" (PDF page 22) -- title unreadable in the layer; not reconstructed.
- "" (PDF page 32) -- title unreadable in the layer; not reconstructed.
- "" after "ANOTHER PLAGE, ANOJHER TIME" (PDF page 18) and after "THE HOUSE ON MAPLES TEREET" (PDF page 36) -- titles kept exactly as the scan layer renders

them.

Story text transcribed from the embedded text layer: the introduction (PDF page 9) and the fourteen title-and-caption pairs (PDF pages 10, 12, 14, 16, 18, 20, 22, 24, 26, 28, 30, 32, 34, 36). Captions for the drawings on pages 10 ("ARCHIE SMITH, BOY WONDER"), 22 and 32 are garbled in the layer and flagged above rather than reconstructed; titles on pages 18 ("ANOTHER PLAGE, ANOJHER TIME") and 36 ("THE HOUSE ON MAPLES TEREET") carry scan substitutions preserved as embedded. Jacket and blurb matter (pages 1-2), the title page (page 7), copyright and cataloguing data (page 8), praise pages (page 43) and closing matter (pages 41-42, 44) are not included as story prose. Pixel-level visual verification against the rendered scans has not yet been completed -- my image-reading tool is currently unavailable, so please check the transcript against the PDF before treating it as final.